

NIGHT INN

Storywriter Brief - Clean Version

For a short 20-30 minute psychological horror demo.

Quick Summary

- Amy is a struggling mother who takes a night receptionist job at Night Inn.
- Her 6-year-old daughter, Rubi, is placed in a hotel room while Amy works.
- The demo needs a stronger middle section where the reception shift becomes playable horror, not filler.
- The ending involves Amy trying to protect "Rubi," only to realize it is the Wraith mimicking her.

Current Problem

- The beginning and ending are clearer than the middle.
- The middle needs scene flow, actual dialogue, and gameplay events built around the reception shift.
- The exact rule list is not final. Write around the rulebook idea without locking every rule too early.
- Rule suggestions are welcome if they support the story, monsters, and gameplay tension.

Characters

- **Amy:** Main playable character.
 - Single mother under pressure, low on money, staying out of her car with Rubi.
 - Protective, tired, guilty, and desperate; not stupid or helpless.
 - Her fear for Rubi is what the hotel/entities exploit.
- **Rubi:** Amy's 6-year-old daughter.
 - Innocent, scared, and attached to Amy.
 - Should speak like a real child: simple, emotional, not overly mature.
 - Her safety is the emotional pressure point of the demo.
- **Owner:** Human owner of Night Inn.
 - Calm, polite, professional, but slightly wrong.
 - Inherited the hotel from his grandfather and is connected to the rules.
 - During the job introduction, he should casually mention the breaker room while the hotel lights flicker on and off.
- **Julia:** Amy's mother.
 - Amy and Julia fell apart because Julia questioned Amy's parenting and treated her like a child.
 - Mainly matters through Amy's guilt, possible calls, and the ending voicemail/SOS.
- **Wraith:** Mimic entity.
 - Uses familiar voices/appearances to manipulate Amy.
 - Can mimic Rubi and weaponize Amy's emotions.
 - Main ending threat.
- **Radical:** Aggressive entity bound by rules.
 - Violent, impatient, shaking/thrashing/banging.
 - Tries to force Amy into breaking rules during the reception shift.
- **Stalker:** Invisible until it is not.
 - Long, lanky entity concept.
 - Use only if needed; not required to be a major demo focus.

Main Settings

- **Car / Road:** Rainy night arrival. Shows Amy and Rubi are tired and desperate.
- **Night Inn Exterior:** Small roadside hotel surrounded by forest. Neon "Night Inn" sign. Covered front canopy/overhang.
- **Lobby / Red Reception Desk:** Main gameplay area: guests, keys, phone, bell, rulebook, entity pressure.
- **Rubi's Room:** Where Amy leaves Rubi. Tenant rules / welcome box can be planted here.
- **Hallway / Stairs:** Unsafe transition space between lobby and rooms.
- **Breaker Room:** Power/lights system. Mentioned by Owner early while lights flicker, then used later if needed.
- **Closet / Hiding Space:** Ending location where Amy hides with fake Rubi/Wraith.

Mechanics to Write Around

- **Rulebook:** Rules come from a book. It is a gameplay tool, not just lore.
- **Reception:** Amy checks guests, keys, phone calls, and strange desk events.
- **Rules:** Speaking, phone rings, close-eyes/looking-away, hiding, key-giving.
- **Hotel events:** Lights flicker; paintings/walls shake or rumble.
- **Breaker room:** Owner introduces it early while lights flicker. It can later justify leaving the desk.
- **Entities:** Wraith manipulates through mimicry. Radical pressures Amy physically while still bound by rules.
- **Gift box idea:** Old Scratch version used a gift box for rules at check-in. This can become Tenant Rules / welcome box.

Scene Flow

1. Rainy Arrival

Setting: Car / road outside Night Inn, 9:34 PM, rain.

- Amy and Rubi arrive after Amy gets an unusually fast job response.
 - Rubi is with Amy because Amy does not want to leave her in the car.
 - The hotel should feel like both a chance and a warning.
- Writer note:** Keep dialogue short. Show Amy's stress without dumping backstory.

2. Owner Introduction / Job Offer

Setting: Lobby / front desk.

- Owner welcomes Amy and explains the night receptionist job.
 - He asks Amy to start the 8-hour shift at 10 PM because it pays extra.
 - Amy asks for a room for Rubi.
 - Owner offers a room deal tied to Amy staying/working.
 - While he introduces the job, the hotel lights flicker on and off.
 - Owner casually brings up the breaker room, as if the lights acting up is normal.
 - Amy signs because the offer is too good to lose.
- Writer note:** Owner should be polite and controlled, not openly evil. The breaker room mention should feel casual but suspicious.

3. Rubi Gets a Room

Setting: Hallway and assigned room.

- Amy takes Rubi upstairs/through the hall to the room.
 - Amy settles Rubi in and tells her not to leave.
 - A Tenant Rules book/list or welcome box can be visible in the room.
 - Amy notices it but leaves to start the shift.
- Writer note:** Rushed mother-daughter scene. This plants the rules Amy ignores.

4. Reception Rules Found

Setting: Reception desk at 10 PM.

- Owner tells Amy where the desk items are before leaving.
 - Amy opens the drawer and finds the Night Inn Reception Rules book.
 - The job seems simple: guests, questions, phone, keys.
 - The rules make it clear something is wrong.
- Writer note:** Transition into gameplay. Confusion first, fear later.

5. First Check-In

Setting: Reception desk / lobby.

- First guest teaches the basic reception loop.
 - Amy checks the rulebook or desk notes.
 - Amy gives/refuses a key based on the rules.
 - Interaction is slightly off but not deadly.
- Writer note:** This should teach gameplay through a scene, not exposition.

6. Rules Become Real

Setting: Reception desk, phone, lights, lobby.

- Phone rings start testing Amy.
- A guest behaves in a way tied to speaking/key rules.
- Lights flicker; paintings/walls shake or rumble.
- Amy starts realizing the rules are survival instructions.

Writer note: This is the main story gap. Build a clean sequence of reception events that escalate.

7. Radical Encounter

Setting: Reception desk / lobby.

- Radical appears in a rule-bound/confined state.
- It shakes, bangs, or thrashes to force panic.
- Amy must follow a rule to survive the encounter.
- This proves entities are bound by rules but still dangerous.

Writer note: Keep this playable. Do not turn it into only a cutscene unless needed.

8. Wraith Pressure

Setting: Phone, lobby, hallway, or near Rubi's room.

- Amy hears or receives something that sounds like Rubi, Julia, or another familiar voice.
- The Wraith uses emotional pressure instead of brute force.
- Amy is pushed toward leaving the desk or breaking a rule.
- The player should question whether the voice is real.

Writer note: Do not reveal the Wraith too early. Plant clues that pay off in the ending.

9. Power / Breaker Event

Setting: Reception desk, hallway, breaker room.

- Lights fail or behave strangely.
- The earlier Owner/breaker room mention pays off.
- Rules may allow Amy to leave the desk for this reason.
- Amy checks/restores the breaker, then returns under pressure.

Writer note: Use only if the demo needs movement away from the desk. Keep it short.

10. Rubi Trap / Rule Break

Setting: Reception, hallway, or near Rubi's room.

- Amy believes Rubi is in danger or outside the room.
- A rule warns her not to trust what she hears/sees.
- Amy breaks or bends the rule because of Rubi.
- This makes her vulnerable to the Wraith.

Writer note: This is the emotional hinge. Amy should sound scared, not melodramatic.

11. Closet Ending

Setting: Dark closet / hiding space.

- Amy hides with who she believes is Rubi.
- Amy tries to contact Julia and may send an SOS/location.
- Amy leaves a desperate final voicemail/message.
- The child says something like "I'm okay, Mommy."
- The voice shifts or something physical reveals it is not Rubi.
- Amy realizes too late it was the Wraith.

Writer note: This needs the strongest dialogue. Keep the final lines human and painful.

12. Optional Rubi Sting

Setting: Rubi's actual room / hallway.

- Rubi hears Amy's voice outside the room.
- She opens the door despite being warned not to.
- She realizes Amy is gone/dead, or the same mimic danger reaches her.

Writer note: Optional. Use only if it strengthens the ending and does not drag the demo.

Dialogue Targets

- **Amy/Rubi:** grounded, emotional, protective.
- **Amy/Owner:** polite but tense; Owner is professional and slightly off.

- **Reception gameplay:** short lines, silence, pauses, pressure.
- **Wraith:** believable mimicry with subtle wrongness.
- **Julia voicemail/SOS:** short, desperate, regretful, not overdone.

What the Writer Should Deliver

- Clean 20-30 minute demo story/script flow.
- Scene order with settings and transitions.
- Actual dialogue for Amy, Rubi, Owner, Wraith/mimic moments, and ending beats.
- A stronger middle section where reception gameplay escalates.
- Rule/lore suggestions only where they support the story and horror.

Do Not Do

- Do not replace the core premise.
- Do not make every scene a cutscene. The reception shift must feel playable.
- Do not overexplain lore through dialogue.
- Do not make Rubi sound too mature.
- Do not expand the demo beyond the prologue/first shift.

Questions the Writer Should Ask

- Which rules are final, and which are placeholders?
- How much dialogue happens during gameplay vs cutscenes?
- Which entity gets the most focus: Wraith, Radical, or both?
- How many reception events should happen before the ending?
- Should the breaker room be required gameplay or optional?
- Should the final Rubi beat be shown or implied?